

WEEK 18

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 19: 1 – 9a, 11 – 21*

The Lord manifests Himself to Elijah.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Ahab told Jez'ebel all that Eli'jah had done, and how he had slain all the prophets with the sword. Then Jez'ebel sent a messenger to Eli'jah, saying, "So may the gods do to me, and more also, if I do not make your life as the life of one of them by this time tomorrow." Then he was afraid, and he arose and went for his life, and came to Beer-sheba, which belongs to Judah, and left his servant there. But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a broom tree; and he asked that he might die, saying, "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life; for I am no better than my fathers." And he lay down and slept under a broom tree; and behold, an angel touched him, and said to him, "Arise and eat." And he looked, and behold, there was at his head a cake baked on hot stones and a jar of water. And he ate and drank, and lay down again. And the angel of the LORD came again a second time, and touched him, and said, "Arise and eat, else the journey will be too great for you." And he arose, and ate and drank, and went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb the mount of God. And there he came to a cave, and lodged there; and behold, the word of the LORD came to him, and he said to him, "What are you doing here, Eli'jah?" And he said, "Go forth, and stand upon the mount before the LORD." And behold, the LORD passed by, and a great and strong wind rent the mountains, and broke in pieces the rocks before the LORD, but the LORD was not in the wind; and after the wind an earthquake, but the LORD was not in the earthquake; and after the earthquake a fire, but the LORD was not in the fire; and after the fire a still small voice. And when Eli'jah heard it, he wrapped his face in his mantle and went out and stood at the entrance of the cave. And behold, there came a voice to him, and said, "What are you doing here, Eli'jah?" He said, "I have been very jealous for the LORD, the God of hosts; for the people of Israel have forsaken thy covenant, thrown down thy altars, and slain thy

prophets with the sword; and I, even I only, am left; and they seek my life, to take it away."

And the LORD said to him, "Go, return on your way to the wilderness of Damascus; and when you arrive, you shall anoint Haz'ael to be king over Syria; and Jehu the son of Nimshi you shall anoint to be king over Israel; and Eli'sha the son of Shaphat of A'bel-meho'lah you shall anoint to be prophet in your place. And him who escapes from the sword of Haz'ael shall Jehu slay; and him who escapes from the sword of Jehu shall Eli'sha slay. I will leave seven thousand in Israel, all the knees that have not bowed to Ba'al, and every mouth that has not kissed him."

So he departed from there, and found Eli'sha the son of Shaphat, who was ploughing, with twelve yoke of oxen before him, and he was with the twelfth. Eli'jah passed by him and cast his mantle upon him. And he left the oxen, and ran after Eli'jah, and said, "Let me kiss my father and my mother, and then I will follow you." And he said to him, "Go back again; for what have I done to you?" And he returned from following him, and took the yoke of oxen, and slew them, and boiled their flesh with the yokes of the oxen, and gave it to the people, and they ate. Then he arose and went after Eli'jah, and ministered to him.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ex. 33: 22, 20; Jn. 1: 18*

R: the Lord said to Moses: when my glory will pass by, I will put you in the cleft of the rock and I will cover you with my hand until I have passed by, * because no one can see God and remain alive.

V: No one has seen God: the unique Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, has revealed Him.

R: because no one can see God and remain alive.

Second Reading. *Nm. 12 – 16, 19*

All these things happened to them as a figure.

A reading from “the Treatise on the mysteries” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

There is also a third testimony, as the Apostle teaches us: “For all our fathers were under the cloud, and all passed through the sea, and were all baptised in relation to Moses in the cloud and in the sea.” And further, Moses himself says in his song: “You sent Your Spirit, and the sea covered them.” You observe that even then holy baptism was prefigured in that

passage of the Hebrews, wherein the Egyptian perished, the Hebrew escaped. For what else are we daily taught in this sacrament but that guilt is swallowed up and error done away, but that virtue and innocence remain unharmed? You hear that our fathers were under the cloud, and that a kindly cloud, which cooled the heat of carnal passions. That kindly cloud overshadows those whom the Holy Spirit visits. At last it came upon the Virgin Mary, and the Power of the Highest overshadowed her, when she conceived Redemption for the race of men. And that miracle was wrought in a figure through Moses. If, then, the Spirit was in the figure, is He not present in the reality, since Scripture says to us: "For the law was given by Moses, but grace and truth came by Jesus Christ." Marah was a fountain of most bitter water: Moses cast wood into it and it became sweet. For water without the preaching of the Cross of the Lord is of no avail for future salvation, but, after it has been consecrated by the mystery of the saving cross, it is made suitable for the use of the spiritual laver and of the cup of salvation. As, then, Moses, that is, the prophet, cast wood into that fountain, so, too, the priest utters over this font the proclamation of the Lord's cross, and the water is made sweet for the purpose of grace. You must not trust, then, wholly to your bodily eyes; that which is not seen is more really seen, for the object of sight is temporal, but that other eternal, which is not apprehended by the eye, but is discerned by the mind and spirit. Lastly, let the lessons lately gone through from the Kings teach you. Naaman was a Syrian, and suffered from leprosy, nor could he be cleansed by any. Then a maiden from among the captives said that there was a prophet in Israel, who could cleanse him from the defilement of the leprosy. And it is said that, having taken silver and gold, he went to the king of Israel. And he, when he heard the cause of his coming, rent his clothes, saying, that occasion was rather being sought against him, since things were asked of him which pertained not to the power of kings. Elisha, however, sent word to the king, that he should send the Syrian to him, that he might know there was a God in Israel. And when he had come, he bade him dip himself seven times in the river Jordan. Then he began to reason with himself that he had better waters in his own country, in which he had often bathed and never been cleansed of his leprosy; and so remembering this, he did not obey the command of the prophet, yet on the advice and persuasion of his servants he yielded and dipped himself. And being forthwith cleansed, he understood that it is not of the waters but of grace that a man is cleansed. And he indeed

doubted before he was healed; you are already healed, and therefore ought not to doubt.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ps. 77: 52, 53; 1 Cor. 10: 2*

R: The Lord made His people depart like a flock, He led them securely and without fear; * and the waters submerged their enemies.

V: Every one in Moses was baptised in the cloud and in the sea;

R: and the waters submerged their enemies.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Obadiah 1 – 21*

Prediction against Edom.

A reading from the prophet Obadiah.

The vision of Obadi'ah. Thus says the Lord GOD concerning Edom: We have heard tidings from the LORD, and a messenger has been sent among the nations: "Rise up! Let us rise against her for battle!" Behold, I will make you small among the nations, you shall be utterly despised.

The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock, whose dwelling is high, who say in your heart, "Who will bring me down to the ground?" Though you soar aloft like the eagle, though your nest is set among the stars, thence I will bring you down, says the LORD. If thieves came to you, if plunderers by night -- how you have been destroyed! -- Would they not steal only enough for themselves? If grape gatherers came to you, would they not leave gleanings? How Esau has been pillaged, his treasures sought out!

All your allies have deceived you, they have driven you to the border; your confederates have prevailed against you; your trusted friends have set a trap under you -- there is no understanding of it. Will I not on that day, says the LORD, destroy the wise men out of Edom, and understanding out of Mount Esau? And your mighty men shall be dismayed, O Teman, so that every man from Mount Esau will be cut off by slaughter. For the violence done to your brother Jacob, shame shall cover you, and you shall be cut off forever.

On the day that you stood aloof, on the day that strangers carried off his wealth, and foreigners entered his gates and cast lots for Jerusalem, you were like one of them. But you should not have gloated over the day of your brother in the day of his misfortune; you should not have rejoiced over the people of Judah in the day of their ruin; you should not have boasted in the day of distress. You should not have entered the gate of my people in the day of his calamity; you should not have gloated over his disaster in the day of his calamity; you should not have looted his goods in the day of his calamity.

You should not have stood at the parting of the ways to cut off his fugitives; you should not have delivered up his survivors in the day of distress. For the day of the LORD is near upon all the nations. As you have done, it shall be done to you, your deeds shall return on your own head. For as you have drunk upon my holy mountain, all the nations round about shall drink; they shall drink, and stagger, and shall be as though they had not been. But in Mount Zion there shall be those that escape, and it shall be holy; and the house of Jacob shall possess their own possessions.

The house of Jacob shall be a fire, and the house of Joseph a flame, and the house of Esau stubble; they shall burn them and consume them, and there shall be no survivor to the house of Esau; for the LORD has spoken. Those of the Negeb shall possess Mount Esau, and those of the Shephe'lah the land of the Philistines; they shall possess the land of E'phraim and the land of Sama'ria and Benjamin shall possess Gilead. The exiles in Halah who are of the people of Israel shall possess Phoenicia as far as Zar'ephath; and the exiles of Jerusalem who are in Sephar'ad shall possess the cities of the Negeb. Saviours shall go up to Mount Zion to rule Mount Esau; and the kingdom shall be the Lord's.

Responsorial. *Obd.3 – 4, 15*

R: The pride of your heart has exalted you; you make your home in the heights and saying your heart: Who can throw me to the earth? * Even if you raise yourself like an eagle and place your nest among the stars, from up there I will make you fall down, says the Lord.

V: The day of the Lord against the peoples is near. As you have done, in the same way will be done to you; that which you have done to the others will fall back on your head.

R: even if you raise yourself like an eagle and place your nest among the stars, from up there I will make you fall down, says the Lord.

Second Reading.

You who are sick, come and get yourself cured.

Beginning of the “Discourse on baptism” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Behold: the dispenser of every good, he who has estimated the years and holds the dominion of time, he has brought us to the day of salvation, in which it is normal for us to render the guests into adoptive sons, the poor participants of grace, **those who were polluted, purified of the sins**. This is the old proclamation that was present a little before the Lord could appear: “Voice of one who cries in the desert: Prepare the way of the Lord, make his paths straight” (Mt. 3:3; cf: Is. 40: 3). I am neither John nor David, but my smallness does not bear any prejudice to the law of the Lord. We do not obey because of reverence towards those who have written the laws, but we submit with fear to the power and the orders of He who makes the laws.

The grace of the King has arrived, which has conceded remission to two classes of tortured people: he has **freed the prisoners** and has **remitted the debts** of the debtors. For this, I also can offer a suitable medicine to these two categories of people, and with great faith I promise that, if they commit themselves, they will receive help. And so that no one thinks that this medicine costs a lot, I announce clearly what **medication the sick** have to use: to the first I promise health through the waters of baptism, to the others I destroy the evil by means of a few tears.

This simple medication and the grace of God is enough for such a great result: to be **freed from the wounds** inflicted on us by the bite of the serpent, without having to burn and to cut in order to be healed.

Come therefore, you who suffer, to get yourselves cured and may you not be neglected. When a sickness is continuous and old, the medical skill and care can do nothing. Poor and needy, hurry: come and receive the gifts of the King; and you, sheep, welcome the character and the sign of the cross, help and remedy against evils. Give me your names: I will write them with ink on corruptible books, but God will engrave them on tablets that do not perish, because He writes with His own finger as He wrote once the law for the Hebrews.

Come to him and you will be resplendent and your faces will not be confused (Cfr. Ps. 33:6). Wash yourselves, remove from my sight the evil of your actions” (Is. 1:16). These words were written a long time ago, but their importance has not weakened, on the contrary day by day it is in full vigour. Come out from prison, I implore you. Hate the dark places of vice. **Flee from the devil, cruel guardian of the one who is in chains, he who feeds of the misfortunes of the sinners and those who go in search of him. As God rejoices in our just works, so also the author of sin is delighted for the crimes.**

Abandon the old man like dirty clothes, full of filth and undignified because it is stained by thousands of sins and made with the cloth of iniquity. Receive the vestment of incorruptibility, that Christ Himself offers you already ready to be put on, and do not refuse the gift in order not to offend the one who offers it to you. You have rolled in the mud a long time: hurry to the Jordan: John calls you, but it is Christ who entreats you. The river of grace runs everywhere: it does not have its sources in Palestine nor does it empty itself in the sea nearby, but it irrigates the whole world, it enters into paradise, and **making an inverted course to the four rivers that flow out of it**, it brings you much more precious things than those that have come out of it. Its rich source is Christ: **flowing from Him, it floods the whole world**. It has sweet and drinkable waters, without irritating salt. It is rendered sweet by the presence of the Spirit, like the fountain of Marah because of its contact with wood.

Responsorial. *Ex. 36: 26, 27; Rm. 9: 15*

R: I will give you a new heart. * I will make you live according to my precepts and observe and put into practise my laws.

V: I will use mercy with whom I want; and I will have mercy with whom I want.

R: I will make you live according to my precepts and observe and put into practise my laws.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt 14: 13-21*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Now when Jesus heard this, he withdrew from there in a boat to a lonely place apart. But when the crowds heard it, they followed him on foot from the towns. As he went ashore he saw a great throng; and he had compassion on them, and healed their sick.

When it was evening, the disciples came to him and said, "This is a lonely place, and the day is now over; send the crowds away to go into the villages and buy food for themselves." Jesus said, "They need not go away; you give them something to eat." They said to him, "We have only five loaves here and two fish." And he said, "Bring them here to me."

Then he ordered the crowds to sit down on the grass; and taking the five loaves and the two fish he looked up to heaven, and blessed, and broke and gave the loaves to the disciples, and the disciples gave them to the crowds. And they all ate and were satisfied. And they took up twelve baskets full of the broken pieces left over. And those who ate were about five thousand men, besides women and children.

Third Reading. P. II. C.3

Christ in his majesty is always desirable.

A reading from the work "The sacrament of the Altar" of Baldwin of Canterbury, bishop

"They who eat me will hunger for more, they who drink me will thirst for more" (Sir. 24: 20). In the present time we cannot nourish ourselves with Christ, wisdom of God, up to the point of satisfying our desire, but remaining with the desire of satisfying ourselves; and all the more we taste his sweetness, the more our desire is heightened. Therefore those who eat will hunger for more, until they reach satiety. When the desire of the good will be satisfied they will not have either hunger or thirst anymore.

What has been said can also be applied to the future life: "They who eat me will hunger for more, they who drink me will thirst for more".

There is in fact in that eternal satiety, as a longing, coming not from destitution but from beatitudes: in heaven those who do not need anymore to eat desire always to eat, they are never nauseated by their satiety. There is in fact satiety without nuisance and a desire without agony. Christ, who is always marvellous in his majesty, constitutes unceasingly the object of our desire, he in whom "even the angels long to catch a glimpse" (1 Pet. 1: 12). This is why though possessing him, we desire him and also when we have

reached him we continue to search for him, as it is written: “Search for his face always” (Ps. 104: 4). We search continuously for he whom we love in order to be possessed by him eternally.

Therefore those who find him continue to search for him, those who eat of him are still hungry, and those who drink of him are still thirsty; but this hunger takes away all other hungers and this thirst extinguishes all other thirsts.

It does not come from privation, but from happiness that is accomplished. Of that hunger which is caused by privation it is said in fact: “He who comes to me will never be hungry again and he who believes in me will not be thirsty again” (Jn. 6: 35). Of the hunger that comes from the beatitudes instead it is said: “They who eat me will hunger for more, they who drink of me will thirst for more”. For those who believe in him, Christ is food and drink, bread and wine: he is bread and wine because he strengthens and consolidates, drink and wine because he makes happy. All that in us which is strong, valid and constant, the cheerful happiness with which we observe the commandments of God, bear the suffering, obey and fight for justice: so much strength and so much courage comes to us from that bread, the joy from that drink. Blessed are those who act with strength and joy.

And since no one can do this with his own strength, blessed are those who desire ardently for that which is just and honest, being in everything comforted and cheered by he who says: “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for justice” (Mt. 5: 6).

Then if Christ is the bread and drink that strengthens and gladdens the just in the present life, the greater will he be in the future the fount of their eternal beatitude!

Responsorial. *Ps. 104: 3, 4; Phil. 4: 19*

R: The heart of him who searches for the Lord rejoices, * search for the Lord and his power, search always for his face.

V: In return my God will fulfil all your needs, in Christ Jesus, as lavishly as only God can.

R: search for the Lord and his power, search always for his face.

YEAR B

Gospel. Jn. 6: 24-35

A reading from the Gospel of St. John.

So when the people saw that Jesus was not there, nor his disciples, they themselves got into the boats and went to Caper'na-um, seeking Jesus. When they found him on the other side of the sea, they said to him, "Rabbi, when did you come here?" Jesus answered them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, you seek me, not because you saw signs, but because you ate your fill of the loaves. Do not labour for the food which perishes, but for the food which endures to eternal life, which the Son of man will give to you; for on him has God the Father set his seal."

Then they said to him, "What must we do, to be doing the works of God?" Jesus answered them, "This is the work of God, that you believe in him whom he has sent." So they said to him, "Then what sign do you do, that we may see, and believe you? What work do you perform? Our fathers ate the manna in the wilderness; as it is written, 'He gave them bread from heaven to eat.'" Jesus then said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, it was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven; my Father gives you the true bread from heaven. For the bread of God is that which comes down from heaven, and gives life to the world." They said to him, "Lord, give us this bread always." Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life; he who comes to me shall not hunger, and he who believes in me shall never thirst."

Third Reading. Disc. 18: 26-29

Christ drinks my bitterness in order to give me the sweetness of his grace.

A reading from the "Commentary on Psalm 118" of St. Ambrose, bishop.

"I am small and despised, but I do not neglect your precepts" (Ps. 118: 141). I have the stately participation in the heavenly goods. Already I am welcomed to the honour of the heavenly table: for my banquets there is no need of rainwater, or of the products of the earth or the fruits of the trees. In order to take away the thirst there is no need to search for rivers or springs: Christ is my food, Christ is my drink, the flesh of a God sustains me, the blood of a God quenches my thirst. In order to satisfy myself I certainly do not have to wait for the annual harvest, since Christ offers himself everyday to me.

I will not have a reason to fear that some tempest from heaven or the sterility of the fields will compromise him, provided I persist in a loving and pious devotion.

I do not desire that a rain of quails descends on me, that before I admired, and neither the manna, that before I preferred to all the other types of food; because the fathers ate it, and still were hungry. Mine is such a food that if someone eats of it they will not be hungry again; it is a food that does not fatten the body, but strengthens the heart of man.

Before I admired the bread from heaven; in fact it is written: “he gave them bread from heaven to eat” (Jn. 6: 31); but it was not that. The true bread, was only a figure of that future one: the Father has put aside the bread from heaven for me, that true one. That bread of God that gives life to the world has descended from heaven for me. This is the bread of life: therefore, he who eats life cannot die. In fact, how can he who nourishes himself of life die? How can he who possesses in himself a vital substance fail? Come to him and satisfy yourself, because he is bread; draw near to him and drink, because he is the source; draw near to him and you will be radiant (cfr. Ps. 33: 6) because he is light; come to him and you will be freed, because “there where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom” (2 Cor. 3: 17); draw near to him and you will be absolved, because he is the remission of sins. Ask who he is? Listen to what he says: “I am the bread of life: he who comes to me will not hunger anymore and he who believes in me will not be thirsty again” (Jn. 6: 35). You have heard, you have seen, and you have not believed in him: for this you are dead; but now believe, in order to be able to live. From the body of God gushes out for me an eternal spring: Christ drinks my bitterness in order to give me the sweetness of his grace.

Responsorial. *Jn. 6: 48-51*

R: I am the bread of life. Your fathers ate the manna in the desert and they are dead; * this is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that a man may eat it and not die.

V: I am the living bread that comes down from heaven; if anyone eats of this bread he will live forever.

R: This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that a man may eat it and not die.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 12: 13-21*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

One of the multitude said to him, "Teacher, bid my brother divide the inheritance with me." But he said to him, "Man, who made me a judge or divider over you?" And he said to them, "Take heed, and beware of all covetousness; for a man's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions."

And he told them a parable, saying, "The land of a rich man brought forth plentifully; and he thought to himself, 'What shall I do, for I have nowhere to store my crops?' And he said, 'I will do this: I will pull down my barns, and build larger ones; and there I will store all my grain and my goods. And I will say to my soul, Soul, you have ample goods laid up for many years; take your ease, eat, drink, be merry.' But God said to him, 'Fool! This night your soul is required of you; and the things you have prepared, whose will they be?' So is he who lays up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God."

Third Reading. *Disc. 14: 20-22*

Let us follow the Word, let us search for that rest.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Gregory Nazianzen, bishop.

"Let the sage boast no more of his wisdom, nor the valiant of his valour, nor the rich man of his riches" (Jer. 9: 23), even if he has reached the highest level of wisdom, of riches or of power. I then will add similar things to this: let the one who is famous or renowned not be proud of his glory; nor he who enjoys excellent health for his health; nor he who is beautiful for his attractiveness; nor he who is young for his young age; in a word, let there not be any proud or conceited man who glories in those

things that are praised in this world; instead let the one who wants to boast, boast in only one thing: to know and to search for God; and sympathising in the fate of the unfortunate, let him put aside a little good for the future life.

All the other things are transient and fragile, and, as in a game of stones, the stones are thrown and transferred from one to the other; so nothing belongs to the one who possesses it, which will not be consumed with the passing of time or transferred to others with displeasure. Those instead are sure and stable realities, which will not lack, or dissolve; the hope of him who puts his own faith in it, will not be frustrated.

It seems to me moreover that exactly because no good on this earth is stable and lasting, and whatever other thing made wisely by the creating Word and by that Wisdom which surpasses every mind leaves us deluded, and we see the things changing now in one sense now in another, now transported on high now low or even overturned, and before we can take them in our hands they have already gone far away and escaped from us: exactly for this, I say, seeing their instability and variability, we are pushed and direct ourselves towards the port of the future life. What would we have done if our well-being was secure, while, although fluctuating and fragile, we are attached as though by chains and we are reduced by its deceptive greed and great slavery, that we are not able to think that there is anything better and more precious than the present things? And all this while we are listening and are convinced that we have been created in the image of that God who is in heaven and who attracts us to himself, and of this we are convinced?

“Let he who is wise observe these things and he will understand” (Ps. 106: 43). Who will disregard the transient things? Who will await the things that do not change? Who will consider the present things as if they were not existing? Truly blessed is he who, separating with the Word that which is better from the wicked, putting aside and dividing “decides in his heart the holy journey” (Ps. 83: 6), as the blessed David says. And fleeing with all his strength from this valley of tears, he searches for the supreme goods; crucified with Christ to the world, with Christ he rises and together with him he ascends, heir of a new life that is not transitory or false, where the serpent does not bite anymore during the journey, nor lays snares for the heel, having had its head crushed. The same blessed Michael, observing this fact and mocking the reptiles and those who have only the appearance of good, exclaimed: “Come, let us go up to the mountain of the Lord. Get up!

Be off! There is no resting here. (Mic. 4: 2; 2: 10). These are almost the same words with which our Lord and Saviour exhorts us: "Get up, let us go away from here" (Jn. 14: 31). Saying this, he moved not only his disciples of that time from that place, as someone could perhaps think, but he detached his disciples forever from the earth and from the earthly goods in order to take them towards heaven and the heavenly things.

Let us therefore follow the Word, let us search for that rest; let us despise the riches and the comforts of this life, enriching ourselves only with that which in it is good; that is let us save our souls with almsgiving, distributing our riches to the poor in order to enrich ourselves with the heavenly goods.

Responsorial. *Tt. 2: 12, 13; Ps. 2: 12*

R: Let us live in soberness, justice and piety in this world, * while we are waiting in hope for the blessing which will come with the Appearing of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

V: His anger is very quick to blaze. Happy all who take shelter in him.

R: While we are waiting in hope for the blessing that will come with the Appearing of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 21: 1- 21, 27 – 29*

Elijah, the defender of justice towards the poor.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Now Naboth the Jezreelite had a vineyard in Jezreel, beside the palace of Ahab king of Sama'ria. And after this Ahab said to Naboth, "Give me your vineyard, that I may have it for a vegetable garden, because it is near my house; and I will give you a better vineyard for it; or, if it seems good to you, I will give you its value in money." But Naboth said to Ahab, "The LORD forbid that I should give you the inheritance of my fathers." And Ahab went into his house vexed and sullen because of what Naboth the Jezreelite had said to him; for he had said, "I will not give you the inheritance of my fathers." And he lay down on his bed, and turned away his face, and would eat no food. But Jez'ebel his wife came to him, and said to him, "Why is your spirit so vexed that you eat no food?" And he said to her, "Because I spoke to Naboth the Jezreelite, and said to him, 'Give me your vineyard for money; or else, if it please you, I will give you another vineyard for it'; and he answered, 'I will not give you my vineyard.'" And Jez'ebel his wife said to him, "Do you now govern Israel? Arise, and eat bread, and let your heart be cheerful; I will give you the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite."

So she wrote letters in Ahab's name and sealed them with his seal, and she sent the letters to the elders and the nobles who dwelt with Naboth in his city. And she wrote in the letters, "Proclaim a fast, and set Naboth on high among the people; and set two base fellows opposite him, and let them bring a charge against him, saying, 'You have cursed God and the king.' Then take him out, and stone him to death." And the men of his city, the elders and the nobles who dwelt in his city, did as Jez'ebel had sent word to them. As it was written in the letters that she had sent to them, they proclaimed a fast, and set Naboth on high among the people. And the two base fellows came in and sat opposite him; and the base fellows brought a charge against Naboth, in the presence of the people, saying, "Naboth cursed God and the king." So they took him outside the city, and stoned him

to death with stones. Then they sent to Jez'ebel, saying, "Naboth has been stoned; he is dead." As soon as Jez'ebel heard that Naboth had been stoned and was dead, Jez'ebel said to Ahab, "Arise, take possession of the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite, which he refused to give you for money; for Naboth is not alive, but dead." And as soon as Ahab heard that Naboth was dead, Ahab arose to go down to the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite, to take possession of it.

Then the word of the LORD came to Eli'jah the Tishbite, saying, "Arise, go down to meet Ahab king of Israel, who is in Sama'ria; behold, he is in the vineyard of Naboth, where he has gone to take possession. And you shall say to him, `Thus says the LORD, "Have you killed, and also taken possession?"' And you shall say to him, `Thus says the LORD: "In the place where dogs licked up the blood of Naboth shall dogs lick your own blood.'"" Ahab said to Eli'jah, "Have you found me, O my enemy?" He answered, "I have found you, because you have sold yourself to do what is evil in the sight of the LORD. Behold, I will bring evil upon you; I will utterly sweep you away, and will cut off from Ahab every male, bond or free, in Israel;

And when Ahab heard those words, he rent his clothes, and put sackcloth upon his flesh, and fasted and lay in sackcloth, and went about dejectedly. And the word of the LORD came to Eli'jah the Tishbite, saying, Have you seen how Ahab has humbled himself before me? Because he has humbled himself before me, I will not bring the evil in his days; but in his son's days I will bring the evil upon his house."

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jm. 4;8. 9. 10; 5, 6*

R: Wash your hands, you sinners, purify your hearts, you irresolute men. *
Mourn and cry, humble yourselves before the Lord.

V: You have condemned and killed the just one, and he could not offer resistance.

R: Mourn and cry, humble yourselves before the Lord.

Second Reading. *Nm. 19 – 21, 24, 26 – 38*

Water does not purify without the Spirit.

A reading from the “Treatise on the mysteries” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

The reason why you were told before not to believe only what you saw was that you might not say perchance, This is that great mystery “which eye has not seen, nor ear heard, neither has it entered into the heart of man.” I see water, which I have been used to see every day. Is that water to cleanse me now in which I have so often bathed without ever being cleansed? By this you may recognise that **water does not cleanse without the Spirit.**

Therefore read that the three witnesses in baptism, **the water, the blood, and the Spirit,** are one, for if you take away one of these, the Sacrament of Baptism does not exist. For **what is water without the cross of Christ?** A common element, without any sacramental effect. **Nor, again, is there the Sacrament of Regeneration without water:** “For except a man be born again of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.” Now, even the catechumen believes in the cross of the Lord Jesus, wherewith he too is signed; but unless he be baptised in the Name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, he cannot receive remission of sins nor gain the gift of spiritual grace.

So that Syrian dipped himself seven times under the law, but you were baptised in the Name of the Trinity, you confessed the Father. Call to mind what you did: you confessed the Son, you confessed the Holy Spirit. Mark well the order of things in this faith: you died to the world, and rose again to God. And as though buried to the world in that element, being dead to sin, you rose again to eternal life. Believe, therefore, that these waters are not void of power.

Lastly, that paralytic was waiting for a man. And what man save the Lord Jesus, born of the Virgin, at whose coming no longer the shadow should heal men one by one, but the truth should heal the whole. He it is, then, Whose coming down was being waited for, of Whom the Father said to John the Baptist: “Upon Whom you shall see the Spirit descending and abiding upon Him, this is He Who baptises with the Holy Spirit.” And John bore witness of Him, and said: “I saw the Spirit descending from heaven like a dove and abiding upon Him.” And why did the Spirit descend like a dove, but in order that you might see, that you might acknowledge, that that dove also which just Noah sent forth from the ark was a likeness of this dove, that you might recognise the type of the sacrament?

Is there, then, here any room left for doubt, when the Father clearly calls from heaven in the Gospel narrative, and says: “This is My beloved Son, in Whom I am well pleased”? When the Son also speaks, upon Whom

the Holy Spirit showed Himself in the likeness of a dove? When the Holy Spirit also speaks, Who came down in the likeness of a dove? When David, too, speaks: “The voice of the Lord is above the waters, the God of glory thundered, the Lord above many waters”? When Scripture testifies that at the prayer of Jerubbaal, fire came down from heaven, and again, when Elijah prayed, fire was sent forth and consecrated the sacrifice.

Do not consider the merits of individuals, but the office of the priests. Or, if you look at ‘the merits, consider the priest as Elijah. Look upon the merits of Peter also, or of Paul, who handed down to us this mystery which they had received of the Lord Jesus. To those [of old] a visible fire was sent that they might believe; for us who believe, the Lord works invisibly; for them that happened for a figure, for us for warning. Believe, then, that the Lord Jesus is present at the invocation of the priest, Who said: “Where two or three are, there am I also.” How much where the Church is, and where His Mysteries are, does He vouchsafe to impart His presence!

You went down, then (into the water), remember what you replied to the questions, that you believe in the Father, that you believe in the Son, that you believe in the Holy Spirit. The statement there is not: I believe in a greater and in a less and in a lowest person, but you are bound by the same guarantee of your own voice, to believe in the Son in like manner as you believe in the Father; and to believe in the Holy Spirit in like manner as you believe in the Son, with this one exception, that you confess that you must believe in the cross of the Lord Jesus alone.

Responsorial. *Mt. 3, 11; Is. 1, 16 – 17*

R: He who comes after me is more powerful than me: I am not worthy even to undo his sandals; * He will baptise you with the Holy Spirit and fire.

V: Cease to do evil, learn to do good.

R: He will baptise you with the Holy Spirit and fire.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jl. 1: 1, 13 – 2:11*

The day of the Lord is about to come.

A reading from the prophet Joel.

The word of the LORD that came to Joel, the son of Pethu'el: Gird on sackcloth and lament, O priests, wail, O ministers of the altar. Go in, pass the night in sackcloth, O ministers of my God! Because cereal offering and drink offering are withheld from the house of your God. Sanctify a fast, call a solemn assembly. Gather the elders and all the inhabitants of the land to the house of the LORD your God; and cry to the LORD. Alas for the day!

For the day of the LORD is near, and as destruction from the Almighty it comes. Is not the food cut off before our eyes, joy and gladness from the house of our God? The seed shrivels under the clods, the storehouses are desolate; the granaries are ruined because the grain has failed.

How the beasts groan! The herds of cattle are perplexed because there is no pasture for them; even the flocks of sheep are dismayed.

Unto you, O LORD, I cry. For fire has devoured the pastures of the wilderness, and flame has burned all the trees of the field. Even the wild beasts cry to thee because the water brooks are dried up, and fire has devoured the pastures of the wilderness.

Blow the trumpet in Zion; sound the alarm on my holy mountain! Let all the inhabitants of the land tremble, for the day of the LORD is coming, it is near, a day of darkness and gloom, a day of clouds and thick darkness!

Like blackness there is spread upon the mountains a great and powerful people; their like has never been from of old, nor will be again after them through the years of all generations. Fire devours before them, and behind them a flame burns. The land is like the Garden of Eden before them, but after them a desolate wilderness, and nothing escapes them. Their appearance is like the appearance of horses, and like warhorses they run.

As with the rumbling of chariots, they leap on the tops of the mountains, like the crackling of a flame of fire devouring the stubble, like a powerful army drawn up for battle.

Before them peoples are in anguish, all faces grow pale. Like warriors they charge, like soldiers they scale the wall. They march each on his way, they do not swerve from their paths. They do not jostle one another, each march in his path; they burst through the weapons and are not halted.

They leap upon the city, they run upon the walls; they climb up into the houses, they enter through the windows like a thief.

The earth quakes before them, the heavens tremble. The sun and the moon are darkened, and the stars withdraw their shining. The LORD utters his voice before his army, for his host is exceedingly great; he that executes his word is powerful. For the day of the LORD is great and very terrible; who can endure it?

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jl. 2, 11. 12. 13; Ap. 6: 16. 17*

R: Great and terrible is the day of the Lord: Who can sustain it? * So then, return to the Lord your God, because He is merciful and kind.

V: The great day of He who sits on the throne and of the Lamb has come, and who can resist it?

R: so then, return to the Lord your God, because He is merciful and kind.

Second Reading.

Open your soul to the perfect discipline.

A reading from the “Discourse on baptism” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Imitate Joshua, son of Nun: carry the Gospel as he carried the ark; abandon the desert that is the sin, cross the Jordan, hurry to the fountain of life that is Christ, to the land that produces joyful fruits, that according to the promise makes milk and honey flow. Knock down Jericho, that is the old style of life, in order not to leave it full of strength. Chase far away from you the ravenous crow. Offer to the dove the occasion to fly in you: Jesus was the first to make it descend from heaven as an allegorical image; it does not know deceit, it is gentle and fertile; if it finds man purified and tested like silver, it lives voluntarily in him, and inflaming the soul with its fire, as it sits on the eggs, it generates and gives many children. These are the good actions: the honest discourses, faith, religiosity, justice, temperance, chastity, **purity**. These are the children of the Spirit, and also our goods.

Open your soul like a book, and allow us to write the perfect discipline in order not to stammer always like a child and reason like a baby. I am ashamed of you because you do not become an adult person, and you still have to go out with the catechumens like a child who does not know how to conceal the secrets, while it is time that you take conscience of the mystery. Unite yourself to the mystic people and learn the mysterious discourses.

Sing with us those praises that the cherubim of the six wings sing with the perfect Christians. Desire the food that strengthens the soul; taste the drink that makes the heart exult; love the mystery that the elders transmit to the young in a hidden way. Imitate the ardent desire of the Ethiopian eunuch. He, after he had welcomed Philip, who was sent by the Holy Spirit, and made him sit besides him on the chariot, continuing on his way did not realise that he was not only reading, but understanding the wisdom of Isaiah.

He took pleasure in the interpretation, like a puppy takes pleasure in the blood of the slain lamb. With insistence he questioned Philip, until he was lead to the perfect understanding of the prophecy that he held in his hands; and not at all tired he received the baptism that he had asked, without waiting for either a place, nor city or village, nor the baptismal font, because he had understood that the Lord is everywhere and that all water was good for baptism provided that there was the faith of him who received it and the blessing of the priest that sanctified.

Welcome therefore the gift of Christ, because he who receives this sublime and incomparable benefit, with joy is numbered among those who receive the adoption as sons; and by that change for the better all his friends and relations enjoy and rejoice immensely.

Responsorial. *Pr. 3, 11 – 12; 1, 8*

R: My son, do not despise the instructions of the Lord * and do not be bored with his exhortations: because the Lord corrects the one He loves, as the father his beloved son.

V: listen to the instructions of your father and do not despise the teachings of your mother.

R: and do not be bored with his exhortations: because the Lord corrects the one He loves, as the father his beloved son

Gospel. *Mt. 14: 13 – 21*

He lifted up His eyes to heaven and pronounced the blessing
And gave the bread to the disciples, and the disciples distributed them to the crowd.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Now when Jesus heard this, he withdrew from there in a boat to a lonely place apart. But when the crowds heard it, they followed him on foot from the towns. As he went ashore he saw a great throng; and he had compassion on them, and healed their sick. When it was evening, the disciples came to him and said, "This is a lonely place, and the day is now over; send the crowds away to go into the villages and buy food for themselves." Jesus said, "They need not go away; you give them something to eat." They said to him, "We have only five loaves here and two fish." And He said, "Bring them here to me." Then he ordered the crowds to sit down on the grass; and taking the five loaves and the two fish he looked up to heaven, and blessed, and broke and gave the loaves to the disciples, and the disciples gave them to the crowds. And they all ate and were satisfied. And they took up twelve baskets full of the broken pieces left over. And those who ate were about five thousand men, besides women and children.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 22: 1 – 9, 15 – 23, 29, 34 – 38*

The design of God on Ahab, the impious king, is manifested.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

For three years Syria and Israel continued without war. But in the third year Jehosh'aphat the king of Judah came down to the king of Israel. And the king of Israel said to his servants, "Do you know that Ramoth-gilead belongs to us, and we keep quiet and do not take it out of the hand of the king of Syria?" And he said to Jehosh'aphat, "Will you go with me to battle at Ramoth-gilead?"

And Jehosh'aphat said to the king of Israel, "I am as you are, my people as your people, my horses as your horses."

And Jehosh'aphat said to the king of Israel, "Inquire first for the word of the LORD." Then the king of Israel gathered the prophets together, about four hundred men, and said to them, "Shall I go to battle against Ramoth-gilead, or shall I forbear?" And they said, "Go up; for the Lord will give it into the hand of the king." But Jehosh'aphat said, "Is there not here another prophet of the LORD of whom we may inquire?" And the king of Israel said to Jehosh'aphat, "There is yet one man by whom we may inquire of the LORD, Micai'ah the son of Imlah; but I hate him, for he never prophesies good concerning me, but evil." And Jehosh'aphat said, "Let not the king say so." Then the king of Israel summoned an officer and said, "Bring quickly Micai'ah the son of Imlah." And when he had come to the king, the king said to him, "Micai'ah, shall we go to Ramoth-gilead to battle, or shall we forbear?" And he answered him, "Go up and triumph; the LORD will give it into the hand of the king." But the king said to him, "How many times shall I adjure you that you speak to me nothing but the truth in the name of the LORD?"

And he said, "I saw all Israel scattered upon the mountains, as sheep that have no shepherd;

And the LORD said, 'These have no master; let each return to his home in peace.'" And the king of Israel said to Jehosh'aphat, "Did I not tell you that he would not prophesy good concerning me, but evil?" And Micai'ah

said, "Therefore hear the word of the LORD: I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the host of heaven standing beside him on his right hand and on his left; and the LORD said, 'Who will entice Ahab, that he may go up and fall at Ramoth-gilead?' And one said one thing, and another said another. Then a spirit came forward and stood before the LORD, saying, 'I will entice him.' And the LORD said to him, 'By what means?' And he said, 'I will go forth, and will be a lying spirit in the mouth of all his prophets.' And he said, 'You are to entice him, and you shall succeed; go forth and do so.' Now therefore behold, the LORD has put a lying spirit in the mouth of all these your prophets; the LORD has spoken evil concerning you."

So the king of Israel and Jehosh'aphat the king of Judah went up to Ramoth-gilead.

But a certain man drew his bow at a venture, and struck the king of Israel between the scale armour and the breastplate; therefore he said to the driver of his chariot, "Turn about, and carry me out of the battle, for I am wounded." And the battle grew hot that day, and the king was propped up in his chariot facing the Syrians, until at evening he died; and the blood of the wound flowed into the bottom of the chariot. And about sunset a cry went through the army, "Every man to his city, and every man to his country!" So the king died, and was brought to Sama'ria; and they buried the king in Sama'ria. And they washed the chariot by the pool of Sama'ria, and the dogs licked up his blood, and the harlots washed themselves in it, according to the word of the LORD which he had spoken.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jer. 29, 8. 9. 11; Dt. 18, 18*

R: Do not let your prophets draw you into error, with deceit they speak to you in my name. * I know the projects that I have done in your favour, says the Lord.

V: I will raise up a prophet and I will put my words in your mouth.

R: I know the projects that I have done in your favour, says the Lord.

Second Reading. *Nm. 29 – 30, 34 – 35, 37, 42*

Catechesis on the post-baptismal rites.

A reading from the “Treatise on the mysteries” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

After this, you went up to the priest, consider what followed. Was it not that of which David speaks: “Like the ointment upon the head, which went

down to the beard, even Aaron's beard"? This is the ointment of which Solomon, too, says: "Thy Name is ointment poured out, therefore have the maidens loved You and are drawn to You." (Song of Songs 1, 3) How many souls regenerated this day have loved You, Lord Jesus, and have said: "Draw us after You, we are running after the odour of Your garments," (Song of songs 1, 4) that they might drink in the odour of Your resurrection. Consider now why this is done, for "the eyes of a wise man are in his head;" therefore the ointment flows down to the beard, that is to say, to the beauty of youth; and therefore, Aaron's beard, that we, too, may become a chosen race, priestly and precious, for we are all anointed with spiritual grace for a share in the kingdom of God and in the priesthood.

After this white robes were given to you as a sign that you were putting off the covering of sins, and putting on the chaste veil of innocence, of which the prophet said: "You shall sprinkle me with hyssop and I shall be cleansed, You shall wash me and I shall be made whiter than snow." (Ps 50, 9) For he who is baptised is seen to be purified both according to the Law and according to the Gospel: according to the Law, because Moses sprinkled the blood of the lamb with a bunch of hyssop; according to the Gospel, because Christ's garments were white as snow, when in the Gospel He showed forth the glory of His Resurrection. He, then, whose guilt is remitted is made whiter than snow. So that God said by Isaiah: "Though your sins be as scarlet, I will make them white as snow." (Is.1, 18)

The Church, having put on these garments through the laver of regeneration, (Tit. 3,5) says in the Song of Songs: "I am black and comely, O daughters of Jerusalem." Black through the frailty of her human condition, comely through the sacrament of faith. And the daughters of Jerusalem beholding these garments say in amazement "Who is this that comes up made white?" She was black, how is she now suddenly made white? But Christ, beholding His Church, for whom He Himself, as you find in the book of the prophet Zechariah, had put on filthy garments, now clothed in white raiment, seeing, that is, a soul pure and washed in the laver of regeneration, says: "Behold, you are fair, My love, behold you are fair, your eyes are like a dove's," in the likeness of which the Holy Spirit descended from heaven. The eyes are beautiful like those of a dove, because in the likeness of a dove the Holy Spirit descended from heaven.

And then remember that you received the seal of the Spirit; the spirit of wisdom and understanding, the spirit of counsel and strength, the spirit of

knowledge and godliness, and the spirit of holy fear, and preserved what you received. God the Father sealed you, Christ the Lord strengthened you, and gave the pledge of the Spirit in your heart, as you have learned in the lesson from the Apostle. (cfr. 2 Cor. 1:22)

Responsorial. *Cfr. Eph. 1, 13.14; 2 Cor. 1,21 – 22*

R: You who believe, have received the seal of the promised Holy Spirit, deposit of our inheritance, * while waiting for the full redemption of those whom God has acquired.

V: God Himself has signed us with the anointing and has given us the deposit of the Spirit in our hearts,

R: while waiting for the full redemption of those whom God has acquired.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jl. 2: 12 – 27*

Return to me with all your heart.

A reading from the prophet Joel.

"Yet even now," says the LORD, "return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning; and rend your hearts and not your garments." Return to the LORD, your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and repents of evil. Who knows whether he will not turn and repent, and leave a blessing behind him, a cereal offering and a drink offering for the LORD, your God?

Blow the trumpet in Zion; sanctify a fast; call a solemn assembly; gather the people. Sanctify the congregation; assemble the elders; gather the children, even nursing infants. Let the bridegroom leave his room, and the bride her chamber.

Between the vestibule and the altar let the priests, the ministers of the LORD, weep and say, "Spare your people, O LORD, and make not your heritage a reproach, a byword among the nations. Why should they say among the peoples, 'Where is their God?'" Then the LORD became jealous for his land, and had pity on his people.

The LORD answered and said to his people, "Behold, I am sending to you grain, wine, and oil, and you will be satisfied; and I will no more make you a reproach among the nations. "I will remove the northerner far from you, and drive him into a parched and desolate land, his front into the eastern sea, and his rear into the western sea; the stench and foul smell of him will rise, for he has done great things.

"Fear not, O land; be glad and rejoice, for the LORD has done great things! Fear not, you beasts of the field, for the pastures of the wilderness are green; the tree bears its fruit, the fig tree and vine give their full yield. "Be glad, O sons of Zion, and rejoice in the LORD, your God; for he has given the early rain for your vindication, he has poured down for you abundant rain, the early and the latter rain, as before." The threshing floors shall be full of grain, the vats shall overflow with wine and oil. I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten, the hopper, the destroyer, and the cutter, my great army, which I sent among you.

"You shall eat in plenty and be satisfied, and praise the name of the LORD your God, who has dealt wondrously with you. And my people shall never again be put to shame. You shall know that I am in the midst of Israel, and that I, the LORD, am your God and there is none else. And my people shall never again be put to shame.

Responsorial. *Lk. 21, 25. 31; Mk. 13, 33*

R: There will be signs in the sun, in the moon and in the stars, and on the earth people in anguish. * When you see these things happening, know that the kingdom of God is near.

V: Be vigilant, be awake because you do not know when will be the precise moment.

R: when you see these things happening, know that the kingdom of God is near.

Second Reading.

*Love the gifts and the crowns that God has prepared
for the champions of justice.*

A reading from the "Discourses on baptism" of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

All the saints, because of their trust in God and the free profession of their faith, love dangers and offer their bodies to those who want to tear them to pieces or to kill them in various ways; but they were not defeated or subdued by any difficulty awaiting as a prize for their blood and their glorious undertaking, the beatitudes of the kingdom of heaven.

For this Abraham accepted the command to sacrifice his son and Moses suffered in the midst of the extreme difficulties of the desert. Elijah passed in loneliness an existence full of difficulties; and all the prophets, covered with the skins of sheep and goats, lived in afflictions and vexations. For this and for the gospel the evangelists suffered, and the martyrs tolerated the torments of the tyrants. And who is the truly reasonable man, who is the image of God, lover of the heavenly realities, who does not want to even find himself one day among the men who will be resurrected, if he is not found worthy of being praised by God and of receiving honour as a faithful servant. Pushed by this truth, David made his the thirst of the deer, in order to show how great is his desire for God; he desires seeing the face of God in order to enjoy intellectually the embraces. Paul desires to be undressed of the body, as of a heavy and uncomfortable dress, in order to be with Christ: both of them think of the blessed and un-defectable joy. If there is no love for it, all the rest is “vanity of vanities”(Ecl. 1:2).

Christian men, participants of the heavenly vocation, flee from a way of thinking that is worthy of delinquents and evil-doers, and do not retain it a fortune to flee from punishment; love instead the gifts and the crown that God has prepared for the champions of justice. Ask without fraud the baptism, receive the talent and be careful not to leave it fruitless; but, as the parable wants, become heads of ten cities (cfr. Lk. 19, 17). He who has let the baptism languish and has hidden the talent under the earth, will certainly hear what was said to the lazy and negligent servant. He who has been illuminated recently, if he has not united the action to the faith, is like one who has committed a crime.

He was a slave, guilty of innumerable crimes, in the terror of judgement and of the time in which he would have had to give an account. Suddenly the goodness of God will arrive, he will open the prison, he will free the prisoners.

The one who is conceded grace will be praised, conserving in life in His infinite goodness he who had lost the hope of living. He will take consciousness of himself, and live humbly: he will not puff himself up as if

he has done I do not know what, because of the fact that his chains have been loosened. The forgiveness of the evil done witnesses to the mercy of Him who has conceded it, and not the claim to righteousness of him who has received it.

Responsorial. 2 Pt. 1, 4. 3

R: Through Christ, God has given us great and precious goods, * so that through them we could become participants of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of the concupiscence.

V: He has called us with His glory and power.

R: so that through them we could become participants of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of the concupiscence.

Gospel. Mt. 14: 22 – 36

Tell me to come to you across the water.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then he made the disciples get into the boat and go before him to the other side, while he dismissed the crowds. And after he had dismissed the crowds, he went up on the mountain by himself to pray. When evening came, he was there alone, but the boat by this time was many furlongs distant from the land, beaten by the waves; for the wind was against them. And in the fourth watch of the night he came to them, walking on the sea. But when the disciples saw him walking on the sea, they were terrified, saying, "It is a ghost!" And they cried out for fear. But immediately he spoke to them, saying, "Take heart, it is I; have no fear." And Peter answered him, "Lord, if it is you, bid me come to you on the water." He said, "Come." So Peter got out of the boat and walked on the water and came to Jesus; but when he saw the wind, he was afraid, and beginning to sink he cried out, "Lord, save me." Jesus immediately reached out his hand and caught him, saying to him, "O man of little faith, why did you doubt?" And when they got into the boat, the wind ceased. And those in the boat worshiped him, saying, "Truly you are the Son of God." And when they had crossed over, they came to land at Gennesaret. And when the men of that place recognized him, they sent round to all that region and brought to him

all that were sick, and besought him that they might only touch the fringe of his garment; and as many as touched it were made well.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Chor. 20: 1 – 9, 13 – 24*

The great help offered by God to Jehosapaht, the faithful king.

A reading from the second book of Chronicles.

After this the Moabites and Ammonites, and with them some of the Me-u'nites, came against Jehosh'aphat for battle. Some men came and told Jehosh'aphat, "A great multitude is coming against you from Edom, from beyond the sea; and, behold, they are in Haz'azon-ta'mar" (that is, En-ge'di). Then Jehosh'aphat feared, and set himself to seek the LORD, and proclaimed a fast throughout all Judah. And Judah assembled to seek help from the LORD; from all the cities of Judah they came to seek the LORD.

And Jehosh'aphat stood in the assembly of Judah and Jerusalem, in the house of the LORD, before the new court, and said, "O LORD, God of our fathers, are you not God in heaven? Do you not rule over all the kingdoms of the nations? In your hand is power and might, so that none is able to withstand you. Did you not, O our God, drive out the inhabitants of this land before your people Israel, and give it for ever to the descendants of Abraham your friend? And they have dwelt in it, and have built you in it a sanctuary for your name, saying, 'If evil comes upon us, the sword, judgment, or pestilence, or famine, we will stand before this house, and before you, for your name is in this house, and cry to you in our affliction, and you will hear and save.'

Meanwhile all the men of Judah stood before the LORD, with their little ones, their wives, and their children. And the Spirit of the LORD came upon Jaha'ziel the son of Zechari'ah, son of Benai'ah, son of Je-i'el, son of Mattani'ah, a Levite of the sons of Asaph, in the midst of the assembly. And he said, "Hearken, all Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem, and King Jehosh'aphat: Thus says the LORD to you, 'Fear not, and be not dismayed at this great multitude; for the battle is not yours but God's. Tomorrow go down against them; behold, they will come up by the ascent of Ziz; you will find them at the end of the valley, east of the wilderness of Jeru'el. You will not need to fight in this battle; take your position, stand still, and see the victory of the LORD on your behalf, O Judah and Jerusalem.' Fear not, and

be not dismayed; tomorrow go out against them, and the LORD will be with you."

Then Jehosh'aphat bowed his head with his face to the ground, and all Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem fell down before the LORD, worshiping the LORD. And the Levites, of the Ko'hathites and the Kor'ahites, stood up to praise the LORD, the God of Israel, with a very loud voice.

And they rose early in the morning and went out into the wilderness of Teko'a; and as they went out, Jehosh'aphat stood and said, "Hear me, Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem! Believe in the LORD your God, and you will be established; believe his prophets, and you will succeed." And when he had taken counsel with the people, he appointed those who were to sing to the LORD and praise him in holy array, as they went before the army, and say, "Give thanks to the LORD, for his steadfast love endures for ever."

And when they began to sing and praise, the LORD set an ambush against the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Se'ir, who had come against Judah, so that they were routed. For the men of Ammon and Moab rose against the inhabitants of Mount Se'ir, destroying them utterly, and when they had made an end of the inhabitants of Se'ir, they all helped to destroy one another.

When Judah came to the watchtower of the wilderness, they looked toward the multitude; and behold, they were dead bodies lying on the ground; none had escaped.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Eph. 6, 12. 14; 2 Chr. 20, 17*

R: Our battle is not against creatures of flesh and blood, but against the powers and the spirit of evil.

* Be therefore unwavering, armed with the truth.

V: Resist with courage, and you will see the salvation that the Lord will accomplish for you.

R: Be therefore unwavering, armed with the truth.

Second Reading. *Nm. 43, 47 – 49*

On the Eucharist to the neophytes.

A reading from the "treatise on the mysteries" of St. Ambrose, bishop.

The cleansed people, rich with these adornments, hastens to the altar of Christ, saying: "I will go to the altar of God, to God Who makes glad my youth;" for having laid aside the slough of ancient error, renewed with an eagle's youth, it hastens to approach that heavenly feast. It comes, and seeing the holy altar arranged, cries out: "You have prepared a table in my sight." David introduces the people as speaking, where he says: "The Lord feeds me, and nothing shall be wanting to me, in a place of good pasture has He placed me. He has led me forth by the water of refreshment." And later: "For though I walk in the midst of the shadow of death, I will fear no evils, for You are with me. Your rod and Your staff have comforted me. You have prepared in my sight a table against them that trouble me. You have anointed my head with oil, and Your inebriating cup, how excellent it is!"

We have proved the sacraments of the Church to be the more ancient, now recognise that they are superior. In very truth it is a marvellous thing that God rained manna on the fathers, and fed them with daily food from heaven; so that it is said, "So man did eat angels' food." But yet all those who ate that food died in the wilderness, but that food which you receive, that living Bread which came down from heaven, furnishes the substance of eternal life; and whosoever shall eat of this Bread shall never die, and it is the Body of Christ.

Now consider whether the bread of angels be more excellent or the Flesh of Christ, which is indeed the body of life. That manna came from heaven, this is above the heavens; that was of heaven, this is of the Lord of the heavens; that was liable to corruption, if kept a second day, this is far from all corruption, for whosoever shall taste it with holy reverence shall not be able to feel corruption. For them water flowed from the rock, for you blood flowed from Christ; water satisfied them for a time, the Blood satiates you for eternity. The Jew drinks and thirsts again, you after drinking will be beyond the power of thirsting; that was in a shadow, this is in truth.

If that which you so wonder at is but shadow, how great must that be whose very shadow you wonder at. See now what happened in the case of the fathers was shadow: "They drank, it is said, of that Rock that followed them, and that Rock was Christ. But with many of them God was not well pleased, for they were overthrown in the wilderness. Now these things were done in a figure concerning us." You recognise now which are the more

excellent, for light is better than shadow, truth than a figure, the Body of its Giver than the manna from heaven.

Responsorial. *Cfr. 1 Cor. 10, 1 – 2. 11. 3 – 4*

R: Our fathers crossed the sea, all were baptised in Moses in the cloud and in the sea. * These things happened to them as a sign and example.

V: All ate the same spiritual food, all drank the same spiritual drink.

R: These things happened to them as a sign and example.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jl. 3:1 – 4, 8 (Vulg. 2: 28 – 3:8)*

The final judgement.

A reading from the prophet Joel.

"And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. Even upon the menservants and maidservants in those days, I will pour out my spirit.

"And I will give portents in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and terrible day of the LORD comes. And it shall come to pass that all who call upon the name of the LORD shall be delivered; for in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the LORD has said, and among the survivors shall be those whom the LORD calls. "For behold, in those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem, I will gather all the nations and bring them down to the valley of Jehosh'aphat, and I will enter into judgment with them there, on account of my people and my heritage Israel, because they have scattered them among the nations, and have divided up my land.

And have cast lots for my people, and have given a boy for a harlot, and have sold a girl for wine, and have drunk it.

"What are you to me, O Tyre and Sidon, and all the regions of Philistia? Are you paying me back for something? If you are paying me back, I will requite your deed upon your own head swiftly and speedily.

For you have taken my silver and my gold, and have carried my rich treasures into your temples. You have sold the people of Judah and Jerusalem to the Greeks, removing them far from their own border. But now I will stir them up from the place to which you have sold them, and I will requite your deed upon your own head. I will sell your sons and your daughters into the hand of the sons of Judah, and they will sell them to the Sabe'ans, to a nation far off; for the LORD has spoken."

Responsorial. *Jl. 3, 2 – 3. 5 (Vulg. 2,29. 30. 32)*

R: In those days I will effuse my spirit above the men slaves and the woman slaves, I will do prodigies in heaven and on earth. * Whoever will invoke the name of the Lord will be saved.

V: On mount Sion and in Jerusalem there will be salvation, and also for the survivors whom the Lord has called.

R: Whoever will invoke the name of the Lord will be saved.

Second Reading.

"Come, blessed of my Father, receive in inheritance the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world.

A reading from the "Discourse on baptism", of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

He who has received the bath of regeneration, is like a recruit who has just been enrolled in the army, who has not yet accomplished brave or heroic gestures, worthy of a true soldier. It is in the same way therefore that one does not consider himself a strong man because he has put on the belt and cloak, nor does he present himself confidentially to the king to speak to him as if he was one of the family, nor does he ask the recompense that is given to those who have toiled and behaved bravely. So also **you having received the grace, do not believe that you can live with the just and receive their inheritance** if you do not first **face up to many dangers for the faith**, if you have not **declared war on the flesh** and with it you have not **resisted the devil and to all the seductions of the wicked spirits**.

In fact, if it seems better to you, let us take the same words of the Lord, that are pronounced in the common judgement, and teach exactly that which they propose: "Come, blessed of my Father, receive in inheritance the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world" (Mt. 25, 34).

For what reason? Neither because you have been re-clothed with incorruptibility nor because you have washed your sins, but because you have **worked correctly in charity**.

And immediately the list of those who have been nourished, whose thirst has been quenched, who have been re-clothed follows. For this reason the judge, who cannot be deceived, judges in this way.

The grace in fact is a gift of God. Now, he is justly honoured for the behaviour of his own life, but **for the grace received no one asks for a reward, instead he feels a debtor**. For this, illuminated by baptism, we have to be grateful to Him who has benefited us. And our gratitude towards God is demonstrated with the goodness that we have with those who are similar to us, by looking after our salvation and virtue.

Abandon therefore your **stupid opinion, you who appeal to baptism in the last moments of life**; and know that the **faith requires hope as a sister, which is born from a life lived in charity**. Through it we become worthy, through the will and work of God: to Him the adoration now and always, forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Mt. 16, 27; 2 Th. 1: 10*

R: The Son of Man will come in the glory of His Father, with His angels, * and He will render to each one according to his actions.

V: He will come to be glorified in His saints and to be recognised marvellous in all those who have believed in Him;

R: and He will render to each one according to his actions.

Gospel. *Mt. 15: 21 – 28*

Woman, great is your faith.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And Jesus went away from there and withdrew to the district of Tyre and Sidon. And behold, a Canaanite woman from that region came out and cried, "Have mercy on me, O Lord, Son of David; my daughter is severely possessed by a demon." But he did not answer her a word. And his disciples came and begged him, saying, "Send her away, for she is crying after us." He answered, "I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel." But she came and knelt before him, saying, "Lord, help me." And he answered, "It is not fair to take the children's bread and throw it to the dogs." She said,

"Yes, Lord, yet even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters' table." Then Jesus answered her, "O woman, great is your faith! Be it done for you as you desire." And her daughter was healed instantly.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 2: 1 – 15*

Elijah is taken up into heaven.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

Now when the LORD was about to take Eli'jah up to heaven by a whirlwind, Eli'jah and Eli'sha were on their way from Gilgal. And Eli'jah said to Eli'sha, "Tarry here, I pray you; for the LORD has sent me as far as Bethel." But Eli'sha said, "As the LORD lives, and as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So they went down to Bethel. And the sons of the prophets who were in Bethel came out to Eli'sha, and said to him, "Do you know that today the LORD will take away your master from over you?" And he said, "Yes, I know it; hold your peace." Eli'jah said to him, "Eli'sha, tarry here, I pray you; for the LORD has sent me to Jericho." But he said, "As the LORD lives, and as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So they came to Jericho. The sons of the prophets who were at Jericho drew near to Eli'sha, and said to him, "Do you know that today the LORD will take away your master from over you?" And he answered, "Yes, I know it; hold your peace." Then Eli'jah said to him, "Tarry here, I pray you; for the LORD has sent me to the Jordan." But he said, "As the LORD lives, and as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So the two of them went on. Fifty men of the sons of the prophets also went, and stood at some distance from them, as they both were standing by the Jordan. Then Eli'jah took his mantle, and rolled it up, and struck the water, and the water was parted to the one side and to the other, till the two of them could go over on dry ground. When they had crossed, Eli'jah said to Eli'sha, "Ask what I shall do for you, before I am taken from you." And Eli'sha said, "I pray you, let me inherit a double share of your spirit." And he said, "You have asked a hard thing; yet, if you see me as I am being taken from you, it shall be so for you; but if you do not see me, it shall not be so." And as they still went on and talked, behold, a chariot of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them. And Eli'jah went up by a whirlwind into heaven. And Eli'sha saw it and he cried, "My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" And he saw him no more. Then he took hold of his own clothes and rent them in two pieces.

And he took up the mantle of Eli'jah that had fallen from him, and went back and stood on the bank of the Jordan. Then he took the mantle of Eli'jah that had fallen from him, and struck the water, saying, "Where is the LORD, the God of Eli'jah?" And when he had struck the water, the water was parted to the one side and to the other; and Eli'sha went over. Now when the sons of the prophets who were at Jericho saw him over against them, they said, "The spirit of Eli'jah rests on Eli'sha." And they came to meet him, and bowed to the ground before him.

Responsorial. *Mt. 3, 23 – 24; cfr. Lk. 1, 15, 17*

R: Behold, I will send the prophet Elijah before the great and terrible day of the Lord arrives, * to convert the hearts of the fathers towards the children, and the hearts of the children towards the fathers.

V: John will be great before of the Lord: he will walk before Him with the Spirit and strength of Elijah.

R: to convert the hearts of the fathers towards the children, and the hearts of the children towards the fathers.

Second Reading. *Nm. 52 – 54, 58*

This sacrament that you receive is fulfilled with the word of Christ.

A reading from the “Treatise on the mysteries” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

We observe, then, that grace has more power than nature, and yet so far we have only spoken of the grace of a prophet's blessing. But if the blessing of man had such power as to change nature, what are we to say of that divine consecration where the very words of the Lord and Saviour operate? For that sacrament which you receive is made what it is by the word of Christ. But if the word of Elijah had such power as to bring down fire from heaven, shall not the word of Christ have power to change the nature of the elements? You read concerning the making of the whole world: “He spoke and they were made, He commanded and they were created.” Shall not the word of Christ, which was able to make out of nothing that which was not, be able to change things which already are into what they were not? For it is not less to give a new nature to things than to change them.

But why make use of arguments? Let us use the examples He gives, and by the example of the Incarnation prove the truth of the mystery. Did the course of nature proceed as usual when the Lord Jesus was born of

Mary? If we look to the usual course, a woman ordinarily conceives after union with a man. And this body which we make is that which was born of the Virgin. Why do you seek the order of nature in the Body of Christ, seeing that the Lord Jesus Himself was born of a Virgin, not according to nature? It is the true Flesh of Christ which is crucified and buried, which is then truly the Sacrament of His Body.

The Lord Jesus Himself proclaims: “This is My Body.” Before the blessing of the heavenly words another nature is spoken of, after the consecration the Body is signified. He Himself speaks of His Blood. Before the consecration it has another name, after it is called Blood. And you say, Amen, that is, It is true. Let the heart within confess what the mouth utters, let the soul feel what the voice speaks.

For this reason, too, the Church, beholding so great grace, exhorts her sons and her friends to come together to the sacraments, saying: “Eat, my friends, and drink and be inebriated, my brother.” What we eat and what we drink the Holy Spirit has elsewhere made plain by the prophet, saying, “Taste and see that the Lord is good, blessed is the man that hopes in Him.” In that sacrament is Christ, because it is the Body of Christ, it is therefore not bodily food but spiritual. Whence the Apostle says of its type: “Our fathers ate spiritual food and drank spiritual drink,” for the Body of God is a spiritual body; the Body of Christ is the Body of the Divine Spirit, for the Spirit is Christ, as we read: “The Spirit before our face is Christ the Lord.” And in the Epistle of Peter we read: “Christ died for us.” Lastly, that food strengthens our heart, and that drink “makes glad the heart of man,” as the prophet has recorded.

Responsorial. *Mt. 26, 26; Jb. 31, 31*

R: While they were eating Jesus took the bread and, pronouncing the blessing, he broke it and gave it to His disciples saying: * Take this and eat it, this is my body.

V: My people said: To whom has He not given His meat to eat?

R: Take this and eat it, this is my body.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jl. 4:9 – 21 (Vulg. 3: 9 –21)*

After judgement the eternal happiness.

A reading from the prophet Joel.

Proclaim this among the nations: Prepare war, stir up the mighty men.

Let all the men of war draw near, let them come up. Beat your ploughshares into swords, and your pruning hooks into spears; let the weak say, "I am a warrior." Hasten and come, all you nations round about, gather yourselves there. Bring down your warriors, O LORD. Let the nations bestir themselves, and come up to the valley of Jehoshaphat; for there I will sit to judge all the nations round about. Put in the sickle, for the harvest is ripe. Go in, tread, for the winepress is full. The vats overflow, for their wickedness is great.

Multitudes, multitudes, in the valley of decision! For the day of the LORD is near in the valley of decision. The sun and the moon are darkened, and the stars withdraw their shining. And the LORD roars from Zion, and utters his voice from Jerusalem, and the heavens and the earth shake. But the LORD is a refuge to his people, a stronghold to the people of Israel.

"So you shall know that I am the LORD your God, who dwell in Zion, my holy mountain. And Jerusalem shall be holy and strangers shall never again pass through it. "And in that day the mountains shall drip sweet wine, and the hills shall flow with milk, and all the stream beds of Judah shall flow with water; and a fountain shall come forth from the house of the LORD and water the valley of Shittim. "Egypt shall become a desolation and Edom a desolate wilderness, for the violence done to the people of Judah, because they have shed innocent blood in their land. But Judah shall be inhabited forever, and Jerusalem to all generations. I will avenge their blood, and I will not clear the guilty, for the LORD dwells in Zion."

Responsorial. *Jl. 4, 18 (cfr. Vulg. 3, 18); Ap. 22, 17.1*

R: New wine flows out of the mountains and in all the streams of Judah water flows. A fountain will spring up from the house of the Lord. * He who is thirsty let him come, he who wants to draw freely the waters of life.

V: The angel showed me a river of living water, clear as crystal, that gushed out from the throne of God and of the Lamb.

R: He who is thirsty let him come, he who wants to draw freely the waters of life.

Second Reading. *Disc. 7,1.3.5.6.12*

We live in hope.

A reading from the “Discourses on psalm 90” of St. Bernard, abbot.

We live in hope, brothers, and we do not get discouraged in the present trials, because we live in the expectation of joy that will never be lacking. This expectation is not vain for us, nor does the hope give place to doubt, being founded on the promises of the eternal Truth. And then, also from the knowledge of the present gifts the certainty of the future reality can be deduced, and the power of the existing grace gives witness to us with great credibility the joy of the promised glory and what will undoubtedly follow it. In fact “The Lord strong and powerful is the king of glory” (Ps. 23,8).

Our loving faith sustains therefore the battle of this life with virile strength, and suffers serenely every type of persecution. Why not tolerate everything, from the moment that we possess that which is more important than every other thing: the promise for this present life and for the future one? We repel with strength the assailant, because the protector sustains uninterruptedly he who resists, and will not lack in rewarding the victorious with abundance. “His faithfulness- he says – will be your shield and armour. (Ps. 90, 5).

In the mean time therefore, dearest, glorify and carry Christ in your bodies (Cfr. 1 Cor. 6, 20): burden of love, sweet weight, baggage that saves even if some times it seems to oppress, even if some times it beats and scourges the sides of he who resists, even if at times it forces with bit and bridle (cfr. Ps. 31, 9), but always to bring us to happiness. Pay attention with a joyful heart to that which regards the promise of the future life and which is the object of our hope. “Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also” (Lk.12, 34).

Listen to Him who, with the thought and desire, already draws near to the port of salvation, he who has almost thrown the anchor of his hope, seems to already tranquilly possess that desirable land, awaiting all the days of his military life until the hour of change arrives for him (cfr. Jb. 14, 14). It truly deals with a continuous and certain drawing near to that port; this life itself is a preparation for that departure, which is to the divine call.

Finally “Grace and mercy” of God “are reserved for His elected ones” (Ws. 3, 9) and His gaze is on his servants in such a way, that they almost do not pay attention to their left, nor do they hold on tightly with loving protection to the right. It is what the prophet testifies of himself: “I

contemplated the Lord always before me; because He is at my right hand, so that I will not waver" (Acts 2, 25; cfr. Ps. 15, 8). That you may always be at my right hand, O good Jesus! That you may always hold on tight to my right hand! I know in fact with certainty that no adversary can hurt me, that no wickedness will be able to take possession of me.

Responsorial. *Ps. 32; 18. 19; Ps. 33, 8*

R: Behold, the eye of the Lord looks on him who fears Him, on him who hopes in His grace: * to free him from death.

V: The angel of the Lord encamps around those who fear Him.

R: to free him from death.

Gospel. *Mt. 16: 13 – 23*

You are Peter, and I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Now when Jesus came into the district of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, "Who do men say that the Son of man is?" And they said, "Some say John the Baptist, others say Eli'jah, and others Jeremiah or one of the prophets." He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" Simon Peter replied, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God." And Jesus answered him, "Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jona! For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven. And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the powers of death shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven." Then he strictly charged the disciples to tell no one that he was the Christ.

From that time Jesus began to show his disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer many things from the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and on the third day be raised. And Peter took him and began to rebuke him, saying, "God forbid, Lord! This shall never happen to you." But he turned and said to Peter, "Get behind me, Satan! You are a hindrance to me; for you are not on the side of God, but of men."

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 3: 5 – 27*

Elisha prophet of the kings of Judah and Israel

In the war against the Moabites.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

But when Ahab died, the king of Moab rebelled against the king of Israel. So King Jeho'ram marched out of Sama'ria at that time and mustered all Israel.

And he went and sent word to Jehosh'aphat king of Judah, "The king of Moab has rebelled against me; will you go with me to battle against Moab?" And he said, "I will go; I am as you are, my people as your people, my horses as your horses." Then he said, "By which way shall we march?" Jeho'ram answered, "By the way of the wilderness of Edom." So the king of Israel went with the king of Judah and the king of Edom. And when they had made a circuitous march of seven days, there was no water for the army or for the beasts which followed them. Then the king of Israel said, "Alas! The LORD has called these three kings to give them into the hand of Moab." And Jehosh'aphat said, "Is there no prophet of the LORD here, through whom we may inquire of the LORD?" Then one of the king of Israel's servants answered, "Eli'sha the son of Shaphat is here, who poured water on the hands of Eli'jah." And Jehosh'aphat said, "The word of the LORD is with him." So the king of Israel and Jehosh'aphat and the king of Edom went down to him.

And Eli'sha said to the king of Israel, "What have I to do with you? Go to the prophets of your father and the prophets of your mother." But the king of Israel said to him, "No; it is the LORD who has called these three kings to give them into the hand of Moab." And Eli'sha said, "As the LORD of hosts lives, whom I serve, were it not that I have regard for Jehosh'aphat the king of Judah, I would neither look at you, nor see you.

But now bring me a minstrel." And when the minstrel played, the power of the LORD came upon him. And he said, "Thus says the LORD, 'I will make this dry stream-bed full of pools.' For thus says the LORD, 'You

shall not see wind or rain, but that stream-bed shall be filled with water, so that you shall drink, you, your cattle, and your beasts.'

This is a light thing in the sight of the LORD; he will also give the Moabites into your hand, and you shall conquer every fortified city, and every choice city, and shall fell every good tree, and stop up all springs of water, and ruin every good piece of land with stones." The next morning, about the time of offering the sacrifice, behold, water came from the direction of Edom, till the country was filled with water.

When all the Moabites heard that the kings had come up to fight against them, all who were able to put on armour, from the youngest to the oldest, were called out, and were drawn up at the frontier. And when they rose early in the morning, and the sun shone upon the water, the Moabites saw the water opposite them as red as blood. And they said, "This is blood; the kings have surely fought together, and slain one another. Now then, Moab, to the spoil!" But when they came to the camp of Israel, the Israelites rose and attacked the Moabites, till they fled before them; and they went forward, slaughtering the Moabites as they went. And they overthrew the cities, and on every good piece of land every man threw a stone, until it was covered; they stopped every spring of water, and felled all the good trees; till only its stones were left in Kir-har'eseth, and the slingers surrounded and conquered it. When the king of Moab saw that the battle was going against him, he took with him seven hundred swordsmen to break through, opposite the king of Edom; but they could not.

Then he took his eldest son who was to reign in his stead, and offered him for a burnt offering upon the wall. And there came great wrath upon Israel; and they withdrew from him and returned to their own land.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jb. 22, 27; Ps. 80, 8*

R: The Lord will be your help against all your enemies and He will purify you as silver is purified with fire; then you will acquire faith and courage in front of the Lord. * You will beseech Him and He will answer you.

V: You have cried to me in anguish and I have freed you.

R: You will beseech Him and He will answer you.

Second Reading. *Discourse on Elijah taken into heaven.*

Consider, brothers, your vocation.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Aelred, abbot.

Let us take into consideration these four realities: the earthly life of Christ, His passion, His resurrection, and His ascension. He showed Himself on the earth and lived with men in order to call His own. He suffered the passion in order to redeem them, He was resurrected in order to justify them. He called His own in three ways: with the doctrine, by example, with the miracles. That is He taught them with the word, He fulfilled with facts and confirmed with miracles. And in these three ways the world came to be turned completely towards God.

In fact the apostles, sent by Christ, carry everywhere the announcement of the Gospel, “while the Lord worked together with them and confirmed the word with the prodigies that accompanied it” (Mk. 16, 20).

The passion follows. And this is enough. At this point in fact the doctrine of Christ has to be loved, at this point the obedience of His commandments has to be embraced, so sapid does the love of Christ be for us, that neither death nor life nor trials nor tribulations can ever separate us from the love of God that is in Christ.

Many, animated by the example of our Saviour, faithful to the doctrine received from the faith to which they have been initiated, fight happily unto the effusion of blood. The passion is followed by the resurrection. He who is dead with Christ, has to also rise with Him. But there is a first resurrection, that consists in the justification of the soul; it is followed by a second one, that is the glorification of the body, so that with a complete salvation, we become participants of that great ascension in which the total Christ, that is the head with the body, is welcomed into the heavenly Jerusalem.

Consider, brothers, your vocation, and meditate on the fruits. Think of the way in which you have been called, to what, and for what end. You have been called by Christ, called to suffer with Him, with the scope of reigning with Him in eternity.

We then have been called in three ways: with an external call, with the emulation of the good and with an interior inspiration. The external call regards the doctrine; the emulation of the good examples, the intimate inspiration the miracle.

And which miracle is greater than that marvellous transformation of our being, thanks to which man, from impure has become pure, from proud he has become humble, from quick tempered he has become patient, from

evil he has become a saint? He who instructs with the preaching does not ascribe to himself such a great miracle, nor he who conducts in the eyes of men a life worthy of praise; but above all let Him who blows where He wants, when He wants, and inspires good in the measure that He wants, be exalted. To this have we been called so that we can follow the footprints of "He who when insulted did not answer with insults and suffering did not threaten vengeance" (1 Pt. 2, 23). Let us therefore imitate His passion; because "He who says that he lives in Christ, has to behave as He behaved" (1 Jn. 2, 6).

Responsorial. *Eph. 1, 4. 11; Rm. 1, 4*

R: God has chosen us in Christ before the creation of the world, in order to be holy. * In Him in fact we have also been made heirs, having been pre-destined according to the plan of Him who works everything efficaciously, in conformation to His will.

V: Christ was constituted Son of God with power according to the Spirit of sanctification.

R: In Him in fact we have also been made heirs, having been pre-destined according to the plan of Him who works everything efficaciously, in conformation to His will.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Mal. 1:1 – 14; 2: 13 – 16*

Oracle against the negligent and the wicked priests.

A reading from the prophet Malachi.

The oracle of the word of the LORD to Israel by Mal'achi. "I have loved you," says the LORD. But you say, "How have you loved us?" "Is not Esau Jacob's brother?" says the LORD. "Yet I have loved Jacob but I have hated Esau; I have laid waste his hill country and left his heritage to jackals of the desert." If Edom says, "We are shattered but we will rebuild the ruins," the LORD of hosts says, "They may build, but I will tear down, till they are called the wicked country, the people with whom the LORD is angry for ever." Your own eyes shall see this, and you shall say, "Great is the LORD, beyond the border of Israel!"

"A son honours his father, and a servant his master. If then I am a father, where is my honour? And if I am a master, where is my fear? Says the LORD of hosts to you, O priests, who despise my name. You say, 'How have we despised your name?' By offering polluted food upon my altar. And you say, 'How have we polluted it?' By thinking that the Lord's table may be despised. When you offer blind animals in sacrifice, is that no evil? And when you offer those that are lame or sick, is that no evil? Present that to your governor; will he be pleased with you or show you favour? Says the LORD of hosts.

And now entreat the favour of God, that he may be gracious to us. With such a gift from your hand, will he show favour to any of you? Says the LORD of hosts. Oh, that there were one among you who would shut the doors, that you might not kindle fire upon my altar in vain! I have no pleasure in you, says the LORD of hosts, and I will not accept an offering from your hand. For from the rising of the sun to its setting my name is great among the nations, and in every place incense is offered to my name, and a pure offering; for my name is great among the nations, says the LORD of hosts. But you profane it when you say that the Lord's table is polluted, and the food for it may be despised. 'What a weariness this is,' you say, and you sniff at me, says the LORD of hosts. You bring what has been taken by violence or is lame or sick, and this you bring as your offering! Shall I accept that from your hand? Says the LORD. Cursed be the cheat who has a male in his flock, and vows it, and yet sacrifices to the Lord what is blemished; for I am a great King, says the LORD of hosts, and my name is feared among the nations.

And this again you do. You cover the Lord's altar with tears, with weeping and groaning because he no longer regards the offering or accepts it with favour at your hand. You ask, "Why does he not?" Because the LORD was witness to the covenant between you and the wife of your youth, to whom you have been faithless, though she is your companion and your wife by covenant.

Has not the one God made and sustained for us the spirit of life? And what does he desire? Godly offspring. So take heed to yourselves, and let none be faithless to the wife of his youth. "For I hate divorce, says the LORD the God of Israel, and covering one's garment with violence, says the LORD of hosts. So take heed to yourselves and do not be faithless."

Responsorial. *Cfr. Mal. 2, 5. 6; Ps. 109, 4*

R: The covenant with my priest was of life and peace; a covenant of fear, and he feared me. * A faithful teaching was on his mouth, there was no falsehood on his lips.

V: The Lord has sworn an oath and He will not repent: You are a priest forever like Melchisedek.

R: A faithful teaching was on his mouth, there was no falsehood on his lips.

Second Reading. *Book 10:6*

In every place sacrifice and a pure victim is offered to my name.

A reading from the “City of God” of St. Augustine, bishop.

Thus a true sacrifice is every work which is done that we may be united to God in holy fellowship, and which has a reference to that supreme good and end in which alone we can be truly blessed. And therefore even the mercy we show to men, if it is not shown for God’s sake, is not a sacrifice. For, though made or offered by man, sacrifice is a divine thing, as those who called it sacrifice meant to indicate. Thus **man himself, consecrated in the name of God, and vowed to God, is a sacrifice** in so far as **he dies to the world** that **he may live to God**. For this is a part of that mercy which each man shows to himself; as it is written, “Have mercy on your soul by pleasing God.” Our body, too, as a sacrifice when we chasten it by temperance, if we do so as we ought, for God’s sake, that we may not yield our members as instruments of unrighteousness unto sin, but as instruments of righteousness unto God. Exhorting us to this sacrifice, the apostle says, “I beseech you, therefore, brethren, by the mercy of God, that you present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service.” If, then, the body, which, being inferior, the soul uses as a servant or instrument, is a sacrifice when it is used rightly, and with reference to God, how much more does the soul itself become a sacrifice when it offers itself to God, in order that, being inflamed by the fire of His love, it may receive of His beauty and become pleasing to Him, losing the shape of earthly desire, and being remoulded in the image of permanent

loveliness? And this, indeed, the apostle subjoins, saying, “And be not conformed to this world; but be you transformed in the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God.” Since, therefore, true sacrifices are works of mercy to ourselves or others, done with a reference to God, and since works of mercy have no other object than the relief of distress or the conferring of happiness, and since there is no happiness apart from that good of which it is said, “It is good for me to be very near to God,” it follows that the whole redeemed city, that is to say, the congregation or community of the saints, is offered to God as our sacrifice through the great High Priest, who offered Himself to God in His passion for us, that we might be members of this glorious head, according to the form of a servant. For it was this form He offered, in this He was offered, because it is according to it He is Mediator, in this He is our Priest, in this the Sacrifice. Accordingly, when the apostle had exhorted us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, our reasonable service, and not to be conformed to the world, but to be transformed in the renewing of our mind, that we might prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God, that is to say, the true sacrifice of ourselves, he says, “For I say, through the grace of God which is given unto me, to every man that is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think, but to think soberly, according as God has dealt to every man the measure of faith. For, as we have many members in one body, and all members have not the same office, so we, being many, are one body in Christ, and every one members one of another, having gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us.”

This is the sacrifice of Christians: we, being many, are one body in Christ. And this also is the sacrifice which the Church continually celebrates in the sacrament of the altar, known to the faithful, in which she teaches that she herself is offered in the offering she makes to God.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Mi. 6, 6. 8; Dt. 10, 14. 12*

R: What will I offer to the Lord? Man, you have been taught that which is good and which the Lord asks of you: * practice justice, love mercy, walk humbly with your God.

V: To the Lord your God belongs the heavens and the earth. Now what does the Lord your God ask you? To do good:

R: practice justice, love mercy, walk humbly with your God.

Gospel. Mt. 16: 24 – 28

What can man give in exchange for his own soul?

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then Jesus told his disciples, "If any man would come after me, let him **deny himself** and **take up his cross** and **follow me**. For whoever would save his life will lose it, and **whoever loses his life for my sake will find it**. For what will it profit a man, if he **gains the whole world and forfeits his life**? Or what shall a man give in return for his life? For the Son of man is to come with his angels in the glory of his Father, and then he **will repay every man for what he has done**. Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death before they see the Son of man coming in his kingdom."

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 4: 8 – 37*

The son of the Shunammite.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

One day Eli'sha went on to Shunem, where a wealthy woman lived, who urged him to eat some food. So whenever he passed that way, he would turn in there to eat food. And she said to her husband, "Behold now, I perceive that this is a holy man of God, who is continually passing our way. Let us make a small roof chamber with walls, and put there for him a bed, a table, a chair, and a lamp, so that whenever he comes to us, he can go in there." One day he came there, and he turned into the chamber and rested there. And he said to Geha'zi his servant, "Call this Shu'nammite." When he had called her, she stood before him. And he said to him, "Say now to her, See, you have taken all this trouble for us; what is to be done for you? Would you have a word spoken on your behalf to the king or to the commander of the army?" She answered, "I dwell among my own people." And he said, "What then is to be done for her?" Geha'zi answered, "Well, she has no son, and her husband is old." He said, "Call her." And when he had called her, she stood in the doorway.

And he said, "At this season, when the time comes round, you shall embrace a son." And she said, No, my lord, O man of God; do not lie to your maidservant." But the woman conceived, and she bore a son about that time the following spring, as Eli'sha had said to her.

When the child had grown, he went out one day to his father among the reapers. And he said to his father, "Oh, my head, my head!" The father said to his servant, "Carry him to his mother." And when he had lifted him, and brought him to his mother, the child sat on her lap till noon, and then he died. And she went up and laid him on the bed of the man of God, and shut the door upon him, and went out.

Then she called to her husband, and said, "Send me one of the servants and one of the asses, that I may quickly go to the man of God, and come back again." And he said, "Why will you go to him today? It is neither new moon nor Sabbath." She said, "It will be well." Then she saddled the ass,

and she said to her servant, "Urge the beast on; do not slacken the pace for me unless I tell you." So she set out, and came to the man of God at Mount Carmel. When the man of God saw her coming, he said to Geha'zi his servant, "Look, yonder is the Shu'nammite; run at once to meet her, and say to her, Is it well with you? Is it well with your husband? Is it well with the child?" And she answered, "It is well." And when she came to the mountain to the man of God, she caught hold of his feet. And Geha'zi came to thrust her away. But the man of God said, "Let her alone, for she is in bitter distress; and the LORD has hidden it from me, and has not told me." Then she said, "Did I ask my lord for a son? Did I not say, Do not deceive me?"

He said to Geha'zi, "Gird up your loins, and take my staff in your hand, and go. If you meet any one, do not salute him; and if any one salutes you, do not reply; and lay my staff upon the face of the child." Then the mother of the child said, "As the LORD lives, and as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So he arose and followed her. Geha'zi went on ahead and laid the staff upon the face of the child, but there was no sound or sign of life. Therefore he returned to meet him, and told him, "The child has not awaked." When Eli'sha came into the house, he saw the child lying dead on his bed. So he went in and shut the door upon the two of them, and prayed to the LORD. Then he went up and lay upon the child, putting his mouth upon his mouth, his eyes upon his eyes, and his hands upon his hands; and as he stretched himself upon him, the flesh of the child became warm. Then he got up again, and walked once to and fro in the house, and went up, and stretched himself upon him; the child sneezed seven times, and the child opened his eyes.

Then he summoned Geha'zi and said, "Call this Shu'nammite." So he called her. And when she came to him, he said, "Take up your son." She came and fell at his feet, bowing to the ground; then she took up her son and went out.

Responsorial. *2 Chr. 20, 20; cfr. 2 Cor. 1, 9*

R: Believe in the Lord your God and you will be strong; * believe in his prophets and you will be successful.

V: do not put your faith in yourselves, but in God who raises the dead.

R: believe in his prophets and you will be successful.

Second Reading.

He will walk before the Lord with the spirit and strength of Elijah.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Aelred, abbot.

“He will walk in front of Him with the spirit and strength of Elijah, to prepare for the Lord a people that is well disposed” (Lk. 1,17). This people is the primitive Church formed by the Jews; to them, in order to call them and prepare them, the prophet Elijah was sent to exhort them: “Do penance because the kingdom of heaven is near at hand” (Mt. 4, 17). He is called through the gift of mercy and he prepares us with penance. Therefore he is justly called “Tishbite”, which means to turn himself to penance. He is the luminous and shining lamp lit by that woman of God, the wisdom, who had lost the drachma, which is the human race; she lit it so that the house, that is the world, could be brought to penance and in this way that drachma, in which we recognise the shadow of the Church of the pre-destined, could be recovered. “I am not the Christ” he said (Jn. 1, 20), but I have been sent before Him.

Where and why? As to a widow in order to present her to the bridegroom like a shining Church, without wrinkle or stain. the people of Israel were like a widow in that time, because already the sceptre and the commander’s staff had been removed from among the feet of Judah, and there was no legitimate king, nor a holy priest. They were waiting for Him who was to come, the legitimate bridegroom for whom this bride was reserved. She possessed a minimum amount of flour and a minimum quantity of oil. And behold the grain, separated from the chaff and ground in the grinding wheel, is transformed into flour. By chaff I mean the letter, by grain the spiritual science.

Beginning from the days of John the grain is separated from the chaff, the letter from the spirit; and, ground in the grinding wheel of the gospel, becomes flour.

Then the Holy Spirit, the oil of grace is added, and it is transformed into the bread with which Elijah nourishes himself. But certainly, in that time in which the hunger for the word of God was growing, the widow, that is the Jewish people, possessed very little flour and very little oil.

Yet with these few ingredients a small bread cooked under ashes, that is an initial announcement of Christ, is kneaded, thanks to which the people are nourished; until when, all the prophets of Baal having been killed, having been eliminated that is all the errors of the past from their hearts, there begins to appear from afar a small cloud, like the hand of a man, that rises from the sea. (cfr. 1 Kg. 18, 44).

Remember, brothers, how immediately the beating of an abundant rain gives back to the earth its fertility of the past?

Let us contemplate now near the Jordan this our Elijah, who, preaching, reproaching, admonishing and baptising, almost killed the unclean spirits that acted in the sons of the incredulous, chasing them out with the baptism from those who confessed their sins and made a sacred and joyful fear for the coming of the divine Saviour rise up in himself and in the people. “Behold, a small cloud, like a man’s hand, rises from the sea” (1 Kg.18, 44).

In the sea recognise the crowd of sinners and publicans, to whom the holy John says: “Brood of vipers! Who warned you to flee from the retribution that is coming?” (Mt. 3, 7) Among these, as from the depths of the sea, there appears that small cloud of which the prophet Isaiah says: “Behold, the Lord rides on a swift cloud” (Is. 19, 1).

And this is our flesh, that the divine wisdom has wanted to assume from us and for us; light, that is, immune from every sin, in which without doubt, hiding itself like the sun in the clouds, he makes Himself known first of all by the blessed John, who while he preached pointed Him out exclaiming: “Behold the Lamb of God” (Jn. 1, 29); this is that bread cooked under the ashes, of which Elijah nourished himself.

Responsorial. *Lk. 1, 13. 15. 76; Jn. 1, 6*

R: Elizabeth the wife of Zechariah generated a great man, John the Baptist, the forerunner of the Lord: * He prepared the way for the Lord in the desert.

V: A man came sent by God and his name was John.

R: He prepared the way for the Lord in the desert.

First Reading. *Mal. 3: 1 – 24 (Vulg.. 3: 1 – 4: 6)*

The day of the Lord.

A reading from the prophet Malachi.

“Behold, I send my messenger to prepare the way before me, and the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple; the messenger of the covenant in whom you delight, behold, he is coming, says the LORD of hosts. But who can endure the day of his coming, and who can stand when he appears? "For he is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' soap; he will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver, and he will purify the sons of Levi and refine them like gold and silver, till they present right offerings to the LORD. Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem will be pleasing to the LORD as in the days of old and as in former years. "Then I will draw near to you for judgment; I will be a swift witness against the sorcerers, against the adulterers, against those who swear falsely, against those who oppress the hireling in his wages, the widow and the orphan, against those who thrust aside the sojourner, and do not fear me, says the LORD of hosts.

"For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O sons of Jacob, are not consumed. From the days of your fathers you have turned aside from my statutes and have not kept them.

Return to me, and I will return to you, says the LORD of hosts. But you say, 'How shall we return?' Will man rob God? Yet you are robbing me. But you say, 'How are we robbing you?' In your tithes and offerings. You are cursed with a curse, for you are robbing me; the whole nation of you. Bring the full tithes into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house; and thereby put me to the test, says the LORD of hosts, if I will not open the windows of heaven for you and pour down for you an overflowing blessing.

I will rebuke the devourer for you, so that it will not destroy the fruits of your soil; and your vine in the field shall not fail to bear, says the LORD of hosts. Then all nations will call you blessed, for you will be a land of delight, says the LORD of hosts.

"Your words have been stout against me, says the LORD. Yet you say, 'How have we spoken against you?' You have said, 'It is vain to serve God. What is the good of our keeping his charge or of walking as in mourning before the LORD of hosts? Henceforth we deem the arrogant blessed; evildoers not only prosper but when they put God to the test they escape.'"

Then those who feared the LORD spoke with one another; the LORD heeded and heard them, and a book of remembrance was written before him of those who feared the LORD and thought on his name. "They shall be mine, says the LORD of hosts, my special possession on the day when I act, and I will spare them as a man spares his son who serves him. Then once more you shall distinguish between the righteous and the wicked, between one who serves God and one who does not serve him. "For behold, the day comes, burning like an oven, when all the arrogant and all evildoers will be stubble; the day that comes shall burn them up, says the LORD of hosts, so that it will leave them neither root nor branch. But for you who fear my name the sun of righteousness shall rise, with healing in its wings. You shall go forth leaping like calves from the stall. And you shall tread down the wicked, for they will be ashes under the soles of your feet, on the day when I act, says the LORD of hosts.

"Remember the law of my servant Moses, the statutes and ordinances that I commanded him at Horeb for all Israel." Behold, I will send you Eli'jah the prophet before the great and terrible day of the LORD comes. And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the land with a curse."

Responsorial. *Ml. 3, 1; Lk. 1, 76*

R: Behold, I will send my messenger to prepare the way before me. * And the Lord, whom you are seeking, will enter immediately into His temple, and the angel of the covenant, whom you are longing for.

V: You, child, will be called the prophet of the Most High; you will go before the Lord to prepare the way for Him.

R: And the Lord, whom you are seeking, will enter immediately into His temple, and the angel of the covenant, whom you are longing for.

Second Reading. *Nm. 40.45*

I am the alpha and the omega, the first and the last.

A reading from the Pastoral Constitution "Gaudium et Spes" of the second Vatican Council on the Church in the contemporary world.

That the earthly and the heavenly city exist simultaneously and intermingle is a fact recognisable only by faith. It will remain a mystery of

human history- a history that will be constantly disturbed by sinfulness until the splendour of the sons of God is fully revealed.

Pursuing the purpose that is proper to her – that of saving mankind – the Church communicates the divine life to men. But not only that; in some way she casts the reflected light of that life over the entire earth. She does this most of all by the healing and uplifting influence she has on the dignity of the person, by the way she strengthens the bonds which bind human society and imbues the everyday activity of man with a deeper meaning and importance. Thus the Church believes that, through her individual members and her whole community, she can contribute a great deal towards making the family of man and its history more human.

While helping the world and receiving many benefits from it, the Church has a single intention: that God's kingdom may come, and that the salvation of the whole of mankind may be achieved. For every benefit which the pilgrim people of God on earth can offer to the human family stems from the fact that the Church is the universal sacrament of salvation: at one and the same time she both demonstrates the mystery of God's love for man and makes it present among men.

The Word of God, through whom all things were made, was Himself made flesh, so that as a perfect man He could save all men and sum up all things in Himself. The Lord is the goal of human history, the point at which the expectations of history and civilisation converge, the centre of the human race, the joy of every heart, and the answer to all its aspirations. He it is whom the Father has raised from the dead, has lifted on high, and has placed at His right hand, making Him judge of the living and the dead. Enlivened and united in His Spirit, we press onwards on our journey towards that consummation of human history that fully accords with the counsel of God's love: 'To unite all things in Him, things in heaven and things on earth.' (Ep. 1, 10)

The Lord Himself says: "Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense, to repay everyone for what he has done. I am the alpha and the omega, the beginning and the end." (Ap. 22, 12 – 13)

Responsorial. *Cfr. Act. 10, 36; 4, 12; 10, 42*

R: This is the word that God has sent, bringing the good news of peace, through Jesus Christ: * He is the Lord of all, in no one else is there salvation.

V: He has been constituted by God judge of the living and the dead;
R: He is the Lord of all, in no one else is there salvation.

Gospel. *Mt. 17: 14 – 20*

If you have faith nothing will be impossible for you.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And when they came to the crowd, a man came up to him and kneeling before him said, "Lord, have mercy on my son, for he is an epileptic and he suffers terribly; for often he falls into the fire, and often into the water. I brought him to your disciples, and they could not heal him." And Jesus answered, "O faithless and perverse generation, how long am I to be with you? How long am I to bear with you? Bring him here to me." And Jesus rebuked him, and the demon came out of him, and the boy was cured instantly.

Then the disciples came to Jesus privately and said, "Why could we not cast it out?" He said to them, "Because of your little faith. For truly, I say to you, if you have faith as a grain of mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there,' and it will move; and nothing will be impossible to you."